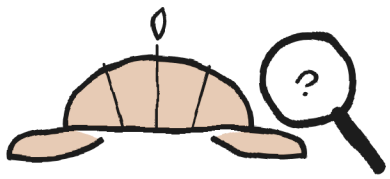
the case of the

TUESDAY GHOST



a sherlock holmes mystery for the modern pipeline

2 a.m., in the fog

the build has failed again. the ops channel lights up like halloween.



holmes, the site reliability engineer, is summoned.

watson (from compliance) brings tea.

lestrade (from management) wants an ETA.

the clues

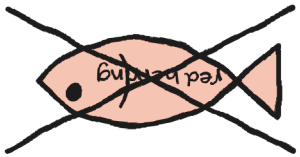


1. it only ever fails on tuesdays.
2. deploy before lunch in singapore: fine. after lunch: kaboom.
3. the logs rotate into a file called `ghost.log`.
4. ghost.log is completely empty.

"curious," says holmes. "very curious."

the usual suspects

a flaky network hop?
a permissions mix-up?
a YAML file cursed by one missing space?



one by one, holmes rules them out. lestrade is not thrilled about how long this takes.

eliminate the impossible, and whatever remains...

elementary tools

holmes doesn't guess. guessing is how you end up blaming the network.



he gathers evidence:

logs: footprints in the snow
traces: telegrams across london
metrics: the system's pulse

and he lines them all up on the same clock.

cut along the dashes

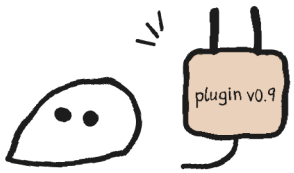
lessons from baker street

- evidence beats opinion.
- keys should expire, like milk.
- postmortems are case files. share them.
- solve the mystery before it solves you.

> case file for you: is there a key in your system that was last rotated *never*?

elementary.

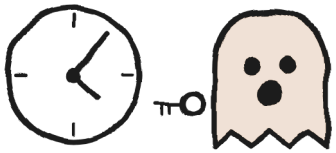
moriarty, unmasked



the ghost was never a ghost. it was a legacy plugin, unpatched since roughly the victorian era, running on a key nobody remembered.

holmes revokes the key, retires the plugin, and writes up the whole case so the next detective solves it in five minutes.

a pattern emerges



every tuesday at **05:07 UTC** (just after lunch in singapore), a forgotten service account wakes up.

its password was last changed: *never*. it gobbles memory until the build falls over, then rotates the logs on its way out.

that's why ghost.log is empty.